

TONGUE¹¹

Observation of the tongue is a pillar of diagnosis because it provides clearly visible clues to the patient's disharmony. Tongue diagnosis is remarkably reliable: whenever there are conflicting manifestations in a

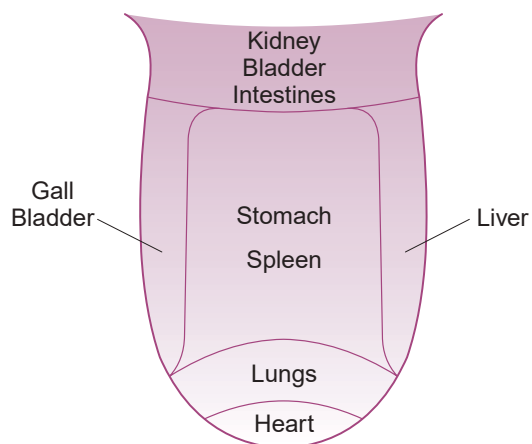


Figure 23.18 Topography of tongue

complicated condition, the tongue nearly always reflects the basic and underlying pattern.

Observation of the tongue is based on four main items: the tongue-body colour, the tongue-body shape, the tongue coating and the moisture:

- The body colour indicates the conditions of Blood, Nutritive Qi and Yin organs: it reflects conditions of Heat or Cold, and Yin or Yang
- The body shape indicates the state of Blood and Nutritive Qi: it reflects conditions of Fullness or Deficiency
- The coating indicates the state of the Yang organs: it reflects conditions of Heat or Cold and of Fullness or Deficiency
- The moisture indicates the state of the Body Fluids

Various areas of the tongue reflect the state of the Internal Organs. A topography of the tongue in common use is as shown in [Figure 23.18](#). As the figure

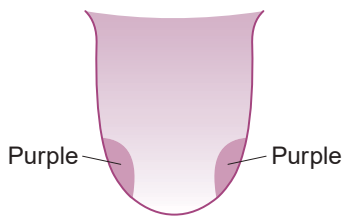


Figure 23.19 Chest areas on the tongue



Figure 23.20 Chest areas of the tongue

shows, the sides of the tongue reflect the state of the Liver and Gall Bladder. However, the sides of the tongue towards the front reflect the chest area, which means the Heart, Lungs and breasts in women (Fig. 23.19 and Fig 23.20).

Box 23.37 summarizes items of observation in tongue diagnosis.

Box 23.37 Items of observation in tongue diagnosis

- Body colour: Blood, Nutritive Qi and Yin organs (Heat/Cold and Yin/Yang)
- Body shape: Blood and Nutritive Qi (Fullness/Deficiency)
- Coating: Yang organs (Heat/Cold and Fullness/Deficiency)
- Moisture: Body Fluids

Tongue-body colour

The normal body colour should be pale red. The body colour reflects the state of Blood and Nutritive Qi and the Yin organs; it reflects conditions of Heat or Cold and of Yin or Yang deficiency.

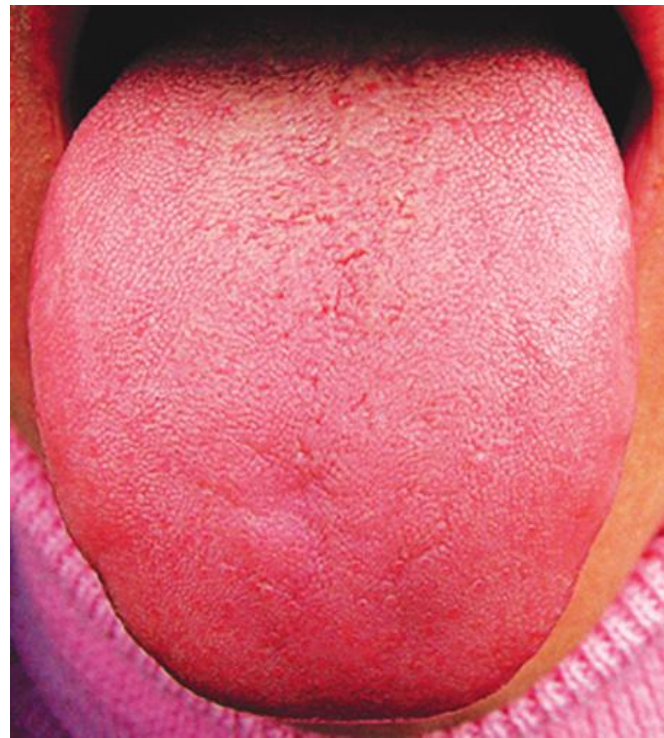


Figure 23.21 Pale tongue-body colour

There are five pathological colours: Pale, Red, Deep-Red, Purple, and Blue.

Pale

A pale body colour indicates either deficiency of Yang or deficiency of Blood. In deficiency of Yang the tongue is also usually slightly too wet, since deficient Yang Qi fails to transform and transport fluids. In deficiency of Blood the tongue tends to be somewhat dry (Fig. 23.21).

If the sides of the tongue are especially Pale, or in severe cases slightly orangey, it indicates deficiency of Liver-Blood.

Box 23.38 summarizes the Pale tongue colour.

Box 23.38 Pale tongue

- Yang deficiency (slightly wet)
- Blood deficiency (slightly dry)
- Pale sides: Liver-Blood deficiency
- Orangey sides: severe Liver-Blood deficiency

Red

By 'Red' is meant too red. A Red tongue body always indicates Heat. If the tongue has a coating, it indicates Full-Heat; if there is no coating, it indicates Empty-Heat (Fig. 23.22).



Figure 23.22 Red tongue-body colour

A Red tip, usually on a Red tongue, indicates Heart-Fire or Heart Empty-Heat, according to whether the tongue has a coating or not. In severe cases, the tip can also be swollen and have red points on it.

Red sides indicate Liver-Fire or Gall Bladder Heat if there is a coating, or Empty-Heat in the Liver if there is no coating. In severe cases they may also be swollen and display red points. A Red centre indicates Heat or Empty-Heat of the Stomach (depending on whether there is a coating or not).

Red tongues are likely to have red points or spots. These are raised papillae and always indicate Heat; if they are rather large (called 'spots' rather than 'points'), in addition to Heat, they also indicate stasis of Blood.

Red points or spots are frequently seen on the tip (Heart-Fire), on the sides (Liver-Fire), on the root (Heat in the Lower Burner) and around the centre (Stomach-Heat) (Fig. 23.23).

Box 23.39 summarizes Red tongue colour.

Deep-Red

This is simply a shade darker than Red and its clinical significance is the same as for the Red tongue, except that the condition is more severe.

Purple

A Purple tongue always indicates stasis of Blood. There are two types of Purple colour: Reddish-Purple and Bluish-Purple.



Figure 23.23 Red points on the tongue sides

Box 23.39 Red tongue

- Red: Heat
- Red with coating: Full-Heat
- Red without coating: Empty-Heat
- Red tip: Heart-Fire or Heart Empty-Heat (former with coating, latter without)
- Red sides with coating: Liver-Fire or Gall-Bladder Heat
- Red sides without coating: Liver-Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat
- Red centre: Heat or Empty-Heat of the Stomach (depending on whether there is a coating or not)
- Red points on the tip: Heart-Fire
- Red points on the sides: Liver-Fire
- Red spots on the root: Heat in the Lower Burner
- Red points in or around the centre: Stomach-Heat

A Reddish-Purple tongue indicates Heat and stasis of Blood, and it develops from a Red tongue (Fig 23.24).

A Bluish-Purple tongue indicates Cold and stasis of Blood, and it develops from a Pale tongue (Fig. 23.25).

A Purple colour is frequently seen on the sides, indicating Liver-Blood stasis, or in the centre, indicating stasis of Blood in the Stomach. A Purple colour on the sides may also reflect Blood stasis in women and, in such cases, it is usually Bluish-Purple.

Please note that most Chinese books say that a Purple tongue may indicate Qi stagnation: I do not



Figure 23.24 Reddish-Purple tongue



Figure 23.25 Bluish-Purple tongue

agree. The tongue-body colour reflects Blood more than Qi and Qi stagnation often may not manifest on the tongue at all. In my experience, if the tongue is Purple, it always reflects Blood stasis.

[Box 23.40](#) summarizes Purple tongue colour.

Box 23.40 Purple tongue

- Always indicates Blood stasis
- Reddish-Purple: Blood stasis from Heat
- Bluish-Purple: Blood stasis from Cold
- Reddish-Purple sides: Liver-Blood stasis
- Bluish-Purple sides in a woman: Blood stasis in the Uterus
- Purple in the centre: Blood stasis in the Stomach

Box 23.41 Tongue-body shape

- Thin: Blood or Yin deficiency (Pale or Red without coating, respectively)
- Swollen: Dampness or Phlegm
- Partially swollen: Heat
- Stiff: interior Wind or Blood stasis
- Flaccid: deficiency of Body Fluids
- Long: Heat
- Short: severe Yang or Yin deficiency (Pale or Red without coating, respectively)
- Cracked: Heat or Yin deficiency
- Quivering: Spleen-Qi deficiency
- Deviated: interior Wind
- Tooth-marked: Spleen-Qi deficiency



A Purple tongue reflects Blood stasis, not Qi stagnation

Blue

The significance of a Blue tongue is the same as a Bluish-Purple tongue: that is, Interior Cold giving rise to stasis of Blood.

Tongue-body shape

The body shape of the tongue gives an indication of Blood and Nutritive Qi and it reflects the Full or Empty character of a condition. [Box 23.41](#) summarizes tongue-body shape.

Thin

A Thin body indicates either Blood deficiency if it is Pale, or Yin deficiency if it is Red and without coating. In both cases, it indicates that the condition is chronic.

Swollen

A Swollen tongue generally indicates retention of Dampness or Phlegm, especially the latter ([Fig. 23.26](#)).



Figure 23.26 Swollen tongue



Figure 23.28 Swollen tongue sides (Spleen area)



Figure 23.27 Swollen tongue sides (Liver area)

A partial swelling usually indicates Heat. A swollen red tip indicates severe Heart-Fire while swollen and red sides indicate Liver-Fire (Fig. 23.27).

Swollen sides that are wider, usually on a Pale tongue, reflect Spleen deficiency (Fig. 23.28). A swelling in the front third of the tongue indicates Phlegm in the Lungs (Fig. 23.29).



Figure 23.29 Swollen Lung area of tongue

Stiff

A Stiff tongue usually indicates interior Wind or Blood stasis (Fig. 23.30).

Flaccid

A Flaccid tongue indicates deficiency of Body Fluids.



Figure 23.30 Stiff tongue

Long

A Long tongue indicates tendency to Heat, and in particular Heart-Heat.

Short

A Short tongue indicates interior Cold if it is Pale and wet, or extreme deficiency of Yin if it is Red and Peeled.

Cracked

Cracks indicate either Full-Heat or deficiency of Yin. Short horizontal or vertical cracks indicate Stomach-Yin deficiency (Fig. 23.31). A long-deep midline crack reaching the tip indicates a tendency to a Heart pattern: I call this a 'Heart crack' (Fig. 23.32).

A shallow, wide crack in the midline not reaching the tip indicates Stomach-Yin deficiency: I call this a 'Stomach crack' (Fig. 23.33).

Short, transverse cracks on the sides, in the middle section of the tongue, indicate chronic Spleen-Qi or Spleen-Yin deficiency.



Figure 23.31 Stomach cracks



Figure 23.32 Heart crack

Quivering

A Quivering tongue usually indicates Spleen-Qi deficiency.

Deviated

A Deviated tongue indicates interior Wind.



Figure 23.33 Stomach crack and rootless coating

Toothmarked

A tongue with teeth marks indicates Spleen-Qi deficiency.

Tongue coating

The tongue coating reflects the state of the Yang organs and in particular the Stomach. It reflects conditions of Heat or Cold and of Fullness or Deficiency.

A normal tongue should have a thin white coating. The tongue coating is formed from some residual 'dirty dampness', which is left over from the Stomach's digestion and reaches the tongue upwards. Thus, a thin white coating indicates that the Stomach is digesting food properly.

The coating gives an indication of the presence or absence of a pathogenic factor and of its strength. A thick coating always indicates the presence of a pathogenic factor and the thicker the coating the stronger the pathogenic factor. Such a pathogenic factor may be exterior or interior, such as exterior Wind, Dampness (interior or exterior), Cold, retention of Food, Phlegm, Heat, Fire.

A coating 'without root' looks as if the coating had been added to the tongue rather than growing out of it (see [Fig. 23.33](#)): this indicates deficiency of Stomach-Qi. The partial absence of coating indicates deficiency of Stomach-Yin ([Fig. 23.34](#)); the total absence of coating indicates deficiency of Stomach-Yin

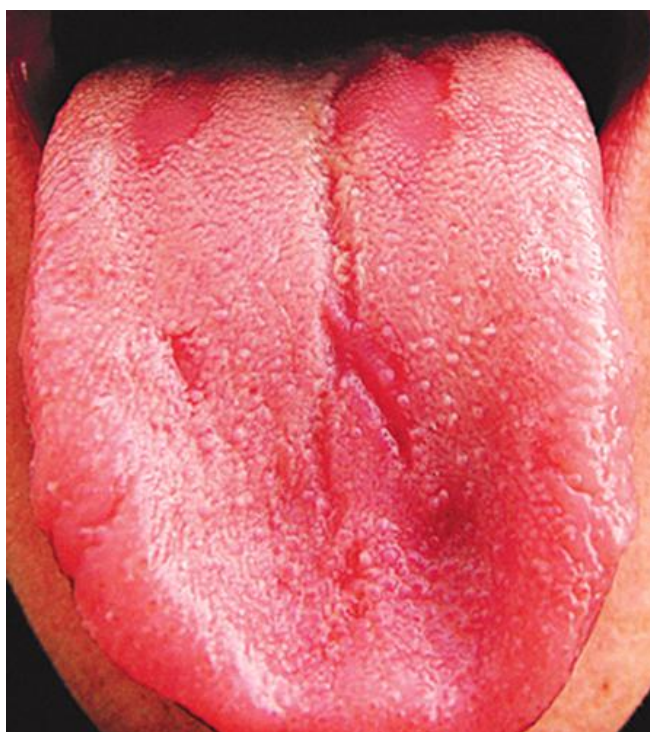


Figure 23.34 Partially peeled tongue



Figure 23.35 Completely peeled tongue

and/or Kidney-Yin ([Fig. 23.35](#)). If the tongue is also Red all over, it is a definite indication of deficient Kidney-Yin with Empty-Heat.

The pathological coating colours can be white, yellow, grey or black.

A white coating indicates a Cold pattern (unless of course, it is thin and white, in which case it is normal).

A yellow coating indicates a Full-Heat pattern.

A grey and black coating can indicate either extreme Cold or extreme Heat, according to whether the tongue is wet or dry.

Box 23.42 summarizes tongue coating signs.

Box 23.42 Tongue coating

- Reflects the state of the Yang organs and in particular the Stomach
- Reflects conditions of Heat/Cold and Fullness/Deficiency
- Normal coating is thin white
- Thick coating: pathogenic factor (the thicker the coating, the stronger the pathogenic factor)
- Absence of coating: Stomach-Yin deficiency
- Total absence of coating, Red tongue body: Stomach- and Kidney-Yin deficiency with Empty-Heat
- White coating: Cold pattern
- Yellow coating: Full-Heat pattern
- Grey and black coating: extreme Cold or extreme Heat (tongue wet or dry, respectively)

Moisture

The amount of moisture on a tongue gives an indication of the state of Body Fluids. Whenever the tongue is Red or Deep-Red, one should check the moisture: if the tongue is also dry, it means that the Heat has begun to injure the Body Fluids.

A normal tongue should be very slightly moist, indicating that the Body Fluids are intact and are being properly transformed and transported.

If the tongue is too wet, it indicates that Yang Qi is not transforming and transporting fluids and these accumulate to form Dampness.

If it is dry, it may indicate either Full-Heat or Empty-Heat, according to whether the tongue has a coating or not.

If the coating is sticky or slippery, it indicates retention of Dampness or Phlegm.

Box 23.43 summarizes tongue moisture signs.

Box 23.43 Moisture of tongue

- Indicates state of Body Fluids
- Normal tongue is slightly moist
- Too wet: Yang deficiency
- Too dry: Heat or Yin deficiency
- Sticky/slippery: Dampness and/or Phlegm